

My Journey to Getting Selected at Amazon

[There is always going to be someone who does things the easy way but that should not stop you from doing things the right way. It is your journey.

-a wise person]

Introduction

Landing a software development role at Amazon has been one of the most rewarding experiences of my life. The journey was challenging, but with determination, preparation, and the right mindset, I was able to secure the position. In this article, I'll share my experience, preparation strategy, and the lessons I learned along the way.

1. Preparation Phase

I began my preparation months before the interview. Since I already had a solid foundation in programming languages such as Python, C, HTML, CSS, JavaScript, PHP, and SQL, I focused on sharpening my problem-solving skills. LeetCode was my go-to resources for solving coding problems but Geeks for geeks will be a greater choice. By the time the interview came around, I had solved around 190 problems on LeetCode, which significantly boosted my confidence

2. The Interview Process

The Amazon interview process was thorough, consisting of several stages, each testing a different aspect of my skillset.

Online Coding Test: The first step was an online coding test that featured algorithmic problems. This stage was crucial as it tested my problem-solving approach, coding efficiency, and understanding of data structures.

Questions asked:

1. Find the minimum distance between two aws stations (something like that)

Example:

Server_stations=[2,5,1,3] //positions of the server stations

Receiver_stations=[1,5,6,2] //positions of the receiver stations

Approach:

Sort the two arrays and sum the absolute difference

2. Write a function that matches a regular expression (with * as a special character) to a given text and returns the length of the longest matching substring.

You can find this question on leetcode:

<https://leetcode.com/problems/wildcard-matching/description/>

Approach:

We have a loop traversing the string. If we find a matching character, the same or a " ? " we move both indices forward.

If we find an " * " we keep the index we found it on and move this and the track of the second index. Lastly we have a loop for the edge case where the " * " is the last char of the string.

It is bit easier to clear this round, most of my solved the two problems (questions asked for everyone were different.).

Code Pair interview: The next phase involved technical interviews where I had to solve problems live while explaining my thought process. This was similar to the coding pair interviews I had practiced for.

Mode: Online

Timings: 1 hour (You should be able to solve both the questions within 1 hour)

Questions asked:

1. You are given two strings and it contains hash ('#') which is a backspace character. If you encounter this special character while traversing the string you should delete the previous character. Finally you should return true if both strings are equal.

Example:

1. S="abbb###c"

T="ac"

Output: True

2. S="abbb##c"

T="abc"

Output: False

Similar question:

<https://leetcode.com/problems/removing-stars-from-a-string/>

The answers I provide:

First I told the brute force approach (using stacks), but the interviewer asked to optimize it. But I was clueless at the time but the interviewer gave me a hint, then I told the optimized approach, the interviewer was satisfied with my answer and asked me to dry run it and finally asked me to code with that optimized approach.

2. Find the next greatest element in a Binary search tree. This is a very basic question on BST, no need to explain further.

Finally they asked me about the time and space complexity.

Tips:

Prepare on topics such as

- 1D and multi dimensional Dynamic programming
- Graph
- Trees
- Linked List

If you solve two questions on time, you will mostly be selected.

Preparation guide:

NeetCode and Greg Hogg at youtube.

All the best.

